being a part of the Pacific Ring of Fire these places are subject to great volcanic eruption and earthquake activities. There are some active volcanoes like Mt Cotopaxi (5,991m) on the Andes range. The Andes are rich in minerals like Copper, Tin and Precious Gems including Emeralds.



Mt Aconcagua



Cotopaxi

The River Basins (or) the Central Plains

Nearly half of the Continent is covered by the plains. Three great rivers drain into the Atlantic Ocean. The biggest of them is the Amazon. The Amazon basin consisting mainly of the alluvial deposits is the thickly forested part of the world. It is widest near the Andes and narrowest near the mouth of the Amazon River. The Orinoco basin is separated from the Amazon basin by low interfluves. It is also one of the most productive parts of the continent. The Parana - Paraguay plain is an ancient rocky surface covered with alluvial deposits and is rich in petroleum deposits.

The Eastern Highlands

These are considerably older than the Andes and are mainly Plateau which is cut by many rivers. They lies to the north and south of the Amazon River. The Guiana Highland is located in the northern part of the continent which has a number of waterfalls including the Angel Falls. The Brazilian Highlands are found to the south of the Amazon basin. They are gently rolling plateaus with steep cliffs along the east coast.

Climate

The climate of the continent of South America has been closely influenced by the latitudes, altitudes and the proximity of the Pacific and Atlantic Oceans. It is hot in the Amazon basin as the equator passes through it whereas Quito, situated almost on the same latitude on the Andes, has "Eternal Spring". That is, it has a pleasant climate throughout the year because of its high altitude at 9,350 feet (or) 2849.88 meter above the sea level. Most of South America regions have its summer from November to January. When it is quite hot in Brazil, Argentina has a relatively cooler climate because of its location in more southerly latitudes.

The rainfall distribution is mainly controlled by the physical features and the distance from the sea. The trade winds bring a lot of rain to the east coast and the Westerlies to the west coast. However, the Amazon basin gets rainfall everyday because of its equatorial location. The regions around the Equator get what is called "4'o Clock

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